

diverse presence of organizations. For instance, Ant Group, a subsidiary of the Alibaba Group, has provided a platform for MSMEs to integrate blockchain into their everyday business easily. The OpenChain project from the Ant Group offers competitive transaction fees to attract more customers. Credit Suisse from Switzerland, on the other hand, has used a blend of Ethereum blockchain and Paxos Settlement Service to allow customers to trade without an intermediary, thereby cutting the costs and time consumed. Fidelity, the mutual-fund giant, and HSBC, the British bank, have also used blockchain's possibilities to increase the efficiency of their financial services.

The numbers rise further when we consider companies with no direct presence in the crypto ecosystem that have integrated blockchain into their infrastructure. A. P. Moller-Maersk, the Danish shipping behemoth, Cargill, the agricultural export conglomerate, Carrefour, a supermarket chain from France, and Sappi, a pulp producer from South Africa, have been using blockchain to handle their supply chains and inventory. A few of them went to the extreme of converting all the transactions to the blockchain platform, which helped the companies to process more consignments than ever before. These companies mostly rely on a combination of suitable blockchain platforms like Hyperledger Fabric and Green-Track. Walmart has used Hyperledger Fabric to address food safety issues by creating a blockchain-backed system for supply management, with expansion plans for 2021.

PharmaLedger, a consortium formed to establish blockchain-enabled Healthcare in the EU, is also on top of the list because it aims to revolutionize the health sector by smoothing the aspects such as supply chains, clinical trials, and health data. Novartis, a reputed drugmaker from Switzerland, has already partnered with PharmaLedger to streamline the process of updating information on prescriptions. Working in tandem with mobile apps and real-time scanning hardware, this project can

address challenges with recalls in the industry and protect the market from black market supply. PharmaLedger is just one of the many blockchain-powered projects in the healthcare sector. BurstIQ, for instance, takes a more sensitive approach towards patient data protection and provides the same information in a quick and accessible manner. It could reduce the rate of drug abuse in the long run.

Other Healthcare-IT companies use blockchain capabilities to improve how the health sector deals with the diagnosis, patient data collection, drug instruction, etc. Considering the increasing investments in the healthcare-IT industry, it is clear that such projects can bring a structural overhaul to how the healthcare sector works.

WHAT DOES 2021 HAVE FOR BLOCKCHAIN TECH?

We can sum up 2020 as the year where blockchain took the first step of widespread acceptance. It is easy to find successful examples for blockchain-based projects in almost every sector. 2021, however, did start with something we probably didn't expect: the 5-figure Bitcoin bull run. Ever since PayPal decided to allow users to pay using crypto, market analysts have been fairly optimistic that digital coins are more likely to become part of everyday life. This change will have implications on how blockchain is used across the globe.

We can also expect the increase of brand-new cryptocurrencies



A hacked together blockchain based logistics device

Credit: Hackster.io

While these success stories are impressive, it doesn't mean every company adopting blockchain has been successful. According to reports, IBM's blockchain business is not going as planned. While it does not mean IBM might have plans to leave the blockchain development business, the organization may have plans to reorient the priorities. We have also heard that Microsoft has created blockchain-based platforms to manage content royalties and rights while dealing with games effectively.

and digital tokens for the changed requirements. Meanwhile, companies worldwide are using blockchain to understand how it can help fight the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic. Systems that can keep track of vaccinations and vaccine supplies are top-priority projects. Thanks to blockchain interoperability and other achievements in the Research & Development wings, blockchain is here to stay and continue its multi-industry presence throughout this year and many more to come. ■